Indian ambassador's diagnosis—however, that was the problem, but the lack of a major shared interest. Earlier, China had served that purpose. After Sino-US rapprochement, however, the US had little or no desire to build or hold India up in contrast to China.

No longer as useful to the US, India found itself overdependent on the Soviet Union. Delhi tried to correct the imbalance between 1973 and 1979. Gandhi had said that India's objective was to "strengthen our friendships, to change indifference into friendship, and to lessen the hostility where it exists."[4] And during this period, that essentially describes the objectives of Gandhi and her successor Morarji Desai with regard to Moscow, Washington, and Beijing, respectively.

As this phase went on, the US and India sought to re-establish and maintain a working relationship to limit the Soviet role in India, but, with China no longer looming as large for either, the US and India slid down the other's priority list for the rest of the Cold War.

This chapter begins with a look at American and Indian attempts to repair relations during the late Nixon years and the Gerald Ford administration. It then outlines developments in Sino-US relations and where India featured in those relations, Delhi's efforts to normalize its relations with Beijing, and its related discussions with the US. The chapter goes on to consider the Jimmy Carter years. It looks at American efforts to open a new chapter with India, and Indian efforts to open a new chapter with China. It ends with the successful normalization of US-China relations and the Sino-Indian rapprochement, which involved one step forward, but half a step back.

Making Up (1973–1976)

In summer 1969, as Nixon prepared for his trip to the subcontinent, Kissinger had asked the president to emphasize to Gandhi that his administration sought good relations not just with Pakistan but also with India, "recognizing India's importance and position vis-à-vis Communist China."[5] After the Sino-US rapprochement, such a role was no longer as necessary—if it was necessary at all.

For over two decades, the US had perceived India through a China prism. By 1973, as Washington continued to build its relationship with